

Nathan Bergman - CSC209 - Ethics Reflection

In short, hardware permissions do not equate to ethical permission. In the scenario, it is clear that my classmate meant to share specific files via the “pub” directory, so anything beyond it is ethically off limits, despite being able to access it.

If there is any reasonable doubt that they don’t want me to access it, I should not. This includes a file that I think I should be able to see but is not in the “pub” directory! If this is the case, it is morally best to double check with the person before accessing it.

This is also regardless of what I plan to do or not do with the files or information. Even if I keep the information to myself, my classmate doesn’t even realize, and a harmless wrong occurs, it is still a violation of their privacy and therefore ethically wrong.

However, if later my classmate says that they changed their mind about the “pub” directory and explicitly say that they want to share everything, then it is fair game. Otherwise, I should only access what I am positive the person is okay with me accessing (i.e. only the files in the designated sharing “pub” directory).

In conclusion, I need clear, unambiguous, nondigital permission from the person on which of their files I can access. This means something written or spoken, without coercion, about every individual file or directory in question. Any doubt, I should play it safe and ask before accessing. This is the case even if my access is harmless. Privacy, including digitally, is a human right, so it is our job as people to mitigate privacy harms in all its forms and ways.